

Long throw routines

A long throw routine is a specific tactical use of the throw-in, where the ball is thrown directly into the penalty area as if it were a cross. This guide explains how long throws work, the teams that use them, and how they are defended.

Set piece routines [Read about throw-ins](#)

What a long throw routine is

A long throw routine uses a throw-in close to the opposition penalty area as if it were a cross.

Most throw-ins in football are short. A team takes the throw to the nearest available teammate and restarts the move. A long throw routine is different — the ball is thrown all the way into the penalty area, with attackers timing runs to meet it, blockers screening defenders, and the throw treated as a deliberate goalscoring opportunity.

Long throws are a tactical specialty rather than something every team uses. They depend on having a player in the team who can throw the ball thirty or more metres accurately, which is a much rarer skill than crossing or shooting. A team without a long-thrower cannot really run long throw routines, no matter how much they want to.

How the routine works

A long throw is treated almost exactly like an inswinging cross.

The thrower

The team's specialist long-thrower takes the throw. They stand on or behind the touchline, use both hands and deliver the ball from behind and over the head, usually with a long flat trajectory into the penalty area.

The target

The thrower aims for a specific area of the box — usually the near post or central penalty spot. The receiving attacker is usually a tall player who can win the header against the defenders.

Specific runners

Attackers time runs to arrive at the right spots in the box as the ball arrives. The first contact is usually a header to flick the ball on or attack the goal directly; teammates arrive to finish or to win the second ball.

Second balls

As with corners, the second ball matters as much as the first. A long throw that creates a half-clearance becomes a chance for whoever wins the loose ball at the edge of the area.

Why some teams use long throws

A long throw is essentially a corner kick from a different starting position. From a tactical point of view, a long throw is a cheap chance to turn a relatively neutral situation — a throw-in near the opposition area — into an attacking set piece. Most other teams give up these positions cheaply, taking the short throw and restarting normal play. A team with a long-thrower turns every one of those throw-ins into a goalscoring threat.

The accumulated effect can be significant. A team that wins several throw-ins per match in advanced areas and turns them into long throws creates extra deliveries that the opposition has to defend. Even if each individual throw is low percentage, the repeated pressure can matter over a season.

The English tradition

Long throws are most associated with English football, although they are not unique to it.

Long throws are strongly associated with English football, especially because several clubs used them prominently in the 2000s and 2010s. Specialist long-throwers became recognisable weapons, and the image of a thrower drying the ball before launching it into the box became familiar.

They are not unique to England, but the tactic fits naturally with direct, set-piece-heavy football cultures. As football has globalised, long throws have appeared in different countries and competitions whenever a team has the right specialist and the right targets in the box.

Defending long throws

Defending a long throw works much like defending a corner.

Marking in the box

Defenders mark the opposition's attackers using zonal, man-to-man or mixed marking — usually the same system the team uses at corners. The most dangerous opposition attackers get specific defenders.

The near-post defender

A defender is often placed near the front of the six-yard area to attack near-post throws, stop flick-ons and protect the goalkeeper.

Foul throws

A long throw with a foot off the ground or an illegal release is a foul throw. Defenders can apply pressure from the legal distance, making the thrower hurry or adjust the delivery without preventing the throw from being taken.

Counter-attack threat

As with corners, long throws can be cleared into space behind the attacking team. Many teams keep one or two attackers high up the pitch when defending long throws, ready to break forward against an opposition that has committed players into the box.

The modern revival

Long throws have had a small modern revival as data-driven set piece coaching has become more common.

For a period in the 2010s, long throws were treated as old-fashioned in much of the top game. Direct, physical attacking set pieces were less popular than possession-based football, and many teams stopped using long throws entirely. They retained popularity at lower levels of the English game but were less visible at the top.

The wave of dedicated set piece coaches that followed has changed this. With set piece routines now subjected to detailed statistical analysis, long throws have re-entered the conversation as a clear extra attacking weapon. A small number of top teams have started using them again, especially when their squad includes a player capable of delivering the throw. The tactical idea has not changed; the willingness to use it has come back.

When to use a long throw

Long throws are most useful in specific situations.

Long throws work best for teams who attack with crosses and have aerial threats in the box. A team built around short passing and ground combinations gets less out of long throws than a team built around physical attackers and direct play. The throw is essentially the same kind of attack as a near-post corner, and the same players who score from corners tend to score from long throws.

They are also more useful late in matches, when teams chasing a goal commit numbers forward. A long throw at minute 85 against a tiring defence is one of the most effective late attacking patterns, particularly because the defending team often has substitutes who have not had the chance to organise themselves at set pieces.